

TOPIC 2: SOCIALISATION:

- Theories of socialisation
- The process of socialisation
- Nature and nurture debate
- The nature of people without socialisation

THE PROCESS OF SOCIALISATION

The process of learning roles and the norms and values appropriate to members of society from those around them is called **socialization**".

◆ Socialization

- Because people are born into an existing society they need to learn (be **socialized**) into the way of the people (culture) of the people thus learning to be human
- Socialization is the process starting from birth ending at death.
 - o It is a process whereby humans become self-aware, knowledgeable and skilled in the ways of the culture into which they are born.
 - o Psychologists believe that a child mind is born empty and as a result everything that a person becomes is learnt through associating with others; that is the socialization process.
- Socialization is the development of the social self; it is the way in which we acquire the social and cultural knowledge of our society. Human personality is developed and shaped through socialization.
- Society, through socialization inculcates in us what makes us feel guilty, anxious or happy.
- The individual being socialized acquires a social self, an awareness of other persons and their expectations and a social personality that reflects/mirrors socially relevant patterns of behaviour, traits and values.
- Socialization therefore makes possible the transmission of culture from one generation to the next and in this way culture is reproduced in the next generation
- It is indeed a lifelong process as we learn new rules in new groups and new situations ending only when one dies.

Sociologists note that socialization occurs on three levels.

- i. Primary socialization:- First socialization that takes place in a child's life; refers to the basic and fundamental aspects of interacting that help an individual develop self-awareness. Here socialization occurs most often through infancy and childhood and is influenced most strongly by the family. In this respect the family is the agent of primary socialization.

The child learns the following in the home:

- To walk
- To talk
- To use various tools such as forks and knives.
- To know the difference between right and wrong
- How to relate properly with others.
- Gender roles: what it is to be masculine or feminine. (Through dress and toys in early life and later through duties assigned.)

- Once the child learns to speak its through language that the child acquires the rest of the culture.
- Many things learnt through primary socialization stay with us for life.
 - o Primary socialization is important to us as it helps us we can apply what we learn to new and different situations. For example, we don't just learn how to relate with adults but to distinguish between different types of adults on the basis of their status and relationship to us (Familiar and unfamiliar adults mean differently to the child).
 - o Children tend to be quiet and shy to strangers; this is even seen in teen agers when they meet strangers: it is because they are not sure of how to behave to these strangers.
- ii. Secondary socialization occurs in later childhood through adolescence. As the social sphere widens, social influence moves beyond the family and extends to peer groups and other nonfamily forces.
 - This socialization is done by agents such as:
 - School
 - Church
 - Peer group
 - Mass media
 - Work place



- o With secondary socialization individuals start to learn; the nature of the social world beyond primary contacts. There is an unemotional relationship outside the family and other primary agents of socialization.
- o Talcott Parsons claimed that one of the main purposes or functions of secondary socialization is to: *"liberate the individual from a dependence upon the primary attachments and relationships formed within the family group."*
 - By this Parsons meant that the majority of people we meet in modern society are strangers to us; we therefore have to deal with them in terms of what they can do for us and what we can do for them in particular situations.
 - In our primary social attachments there is love, trust, affection and so forth, this cannot apply in our secondary social attachments.
- iii. **Finally, adult socialization** occurs as the individual takes on adult roles such as spouse, employee, or parent, adapting to the complexity of changing roles that occurs throughout the adult years.
 - Primary and secondary socialization should reinforce each other but sometimes this is not the case for example when we talk of peer pressure; what is learned in the home differs from what the peers are giving the new member of society.

The theoretical dilemma

- Human beings have the ability to think about and reflect upon the nature of social world and their position in that world.
- This ability allows people to develop values and norms that characterise the culture of society.
- The fact that we are able to do this means that the cultural values and norms that we create reflect back upon us.
 - o We are forced to recognise their existence and this, in turn, shapes the way we think and act through the general socialization process in society.

This therefore creates a theoretical dilemma for all social science

- Our consciousness makes us able to create societies and shape them in any way we choose thus **people create society**.
- On the other hand, the societies we create take on a life of their own that is separate from each individual. Society thus becomes a force we experience influencing our choice of behaviour.
 - If we have to be socialized into becoming a recognisable human being and this socialization process reflects the values and norms of cultures and subcultures, effectively society is creating us and not us creating society.
- 1. On one extreme we have Structuralist sociologists who argue that we are products of society: - **society shapes people in its own image**.
 - However, people do have individual levels of consciousness, creativity, and understanding.
- 2. At the other extreme end are the Interactionist sociologists who emphasize the creative aspects of human individuality: - **people shape society in their own image**.
 - However, for all our supposed individuality we demonstrate very clear and broadly patterns of behaviour that can only have been imposed on us by the social world.
- These are the two theoretical paradigms that show the relationship between the individual and society.

THE CONCEPT OF THE SELF

NATURE AND NURTURE DEBATE

Nurture/Nature debate: - this debate about whether what we come to be; our personality, achievement, way of interacting with others and other aspects of our behaviour is influenced by our genetic make-up (Nature) or by the social environment in which we are brought up (Nurture).

A story is told about triplets who were brought up by three different families only to meet for the first time at college. Many people who knew them as brothers at college agreed that they resembled each other not only physically but also with their mannerisms, likes and dislikes, sense of humour and many more.

- The similarity of physical appearance, personality and mannerisms seems to offer evidence such traits may be genetic components (nature side of the debate); which attributes individual characteristics largely to biological factors.
- In the case of the triplets, because each child was raised in a comfortable home with caring parents they became good humoured (the nurture side of the debate).
- Sociologists argue that despite the role played by biological factors in shaping human behaviour the social environment plays a major part.
- The discovery of untamed or feral children showed that children raised in extreme isolation revealed lack of socialization.

Human Development: Nature and Nurture

- Charles Darwin (1874) demonstrated that much of human behaviour is rooted in our evolutionary history, human development has thus often approached behaviour in terms of whether biology (nature) or society (nurture) is more important to whom we become.
- Recent research however suggests that this approach is too simplistic. Darwin's view of human behaviour has often been misinterpreted as suggesting that humans are solely a product of drives of instinct.
- While Darwin acknowledged that human behaviour had based on biological processes, he also recognized that human beings possessed a unique trait—culture which is an important part of understanding how human beings develop and grow.
- Early misinterpretations of Darwin's theory were instrumental in justifying prejudices and discrimination against certain groups of people whose behaviours were viewed as both primitive and instinctual.
- Variances in cultures were misattributed to differences in intelligence and understanding rather than to differences in the ways in which cultures can be constructed.
- In contrast to the biological view of human behaviour, according to psychologist Watson all behaviour is learned.
- Watson denied that human beings have any instincts at all but rather believed we exist as empty vessels to be filled by social learning. Watson believed that people vary only in their cultural patterns and learning.
- Like Watson, influential anthropologists noted that while cultures, all cultures are equally complex.
- Neither of these extreme views is entirely correct. It is clear that nature does place limits on the ways in which humans can construct culture, as the existence of cultural universals reveals.
- Cultural universals are cultural patterns that are part of every known culture. Because these traits are a part of every known culture, it is difficult to make the argument that the traits are the result simply of social learning. Rather, as Darwin suggested, these universals are probably rooted in our evolutionary history.
- At the same time, the considerable differences of cultures throughout the world attest to the strength and generality of human choice in the construction of culture.
- Other evidence for the influence of culture on the development of the individual can be seen in studies of social isolation.

Development of the self-Mead's Theory of "The Self":

- According to Mead, there are three activities through which the self is developed:
 - o Language,
 - o Play.
 - o Game.
- 1. **Language** allows individuals to take on the “role of the other” and allows people to respond to his or her own gestures in terms of the symbolized attitudes of others.
- 2. During **play**, individuals take on the roles of other people and pretend to be those other people in order to express the expectations of significant others.
 - o This process of role-playing is important to the generation of self-consciousness and to the general development of the self.
 - o Children in their play they take roles of their parents, soldiers, police officers nurses and so on.
 - o Children thus take the role of the significant other (People who appear large to our lives) in their play.
 - o The significant other is the person whose behaviour we seek to model or avoid.
 - o Even though children will be playing the play stage is important in the development of a person’s social behaviour
- 3. In the **game**,
 - o The individual is required to internalize the roles of all others who are involved with him or her in the game and must comprehend the rules of the game.
 - o A person evaluates his/her behaviour according to the group’s ideas of how a role should be performed.
 - o The generalised other is therefore a composite of all the roles of all the participants in a game.
 - o It represents the voice of society which is internalised as a sense of right and wrong (conscience).
 - Mead’s concept of the “generalized other” is also essential to his theory, which he defines as an organized and generalized attitude of a social group.
 - The individual defines his or her own behaviour with reference to the generalized attitude of the social group(s) they occupy.
 - When the individual can view himself/herself from the standpoint of the generalized other, self-consciousness in the full sense of the term is attained. The concept of the generalised other can therefore be used to refer to expectations and standards of the overall society.

The “I” and the “Me”

The ways we choose to behave are influenced by the social background of that behaviour. Mead argued that our behaviour as individuals is conditioned by two aspects of our self-awareness (the ability to see ourselves as others see us and react accordingly).

- According to Mead, the self has two sides.
 1. **The “me” represents the expectations and attitudes of others (the generalized other).**
 - o It is the organized set of attitudes of others that the individual assumes.
 - o The individual is dominated by society through the “me”.
 - o The “me” allows an individual to live comfortably in society.
 - o Conformists are dominated by the “me”.
 - o According to Mead individuals carry society within them and it is this that allows them to control themselves through self-criticism. (*what will people say if they hear I did this and that*)
 2. **The “I” is the response to the “me,” or the person’s individuality.**
 - o The “I” is unpredictable and creative (revolutionary).
 - o It is selfish and does not think of what will happen (it challenges society).
 - o We are never totally aware of the “I” until we surprise ourselves and others with our actions.
 - o We only come to know the “I” after the act has been carried out.
 - The “I” is a major source change and innovation in society as it does not always conform.
- According to Mead, the generalized other (internalized in the “me”) is the major instrument of social control for it is the mechanism by which the community controls over the conduct of its individual members.

An example of how the “I” and the “Me” operate.

If you accidentally put your hand in a fire;

1. The “I” aspect of the self is expressed by the way you react to the pain that you feel.
2. The “Me” aspect of the self, however specifically conditions the choice of your response to the pain that you feel.
 - i. Who you are (social factors such as gender, age and so forth).
 - ii. Where you are (at home, in public etc.).
 - iii. Who are you being with (family, friends, people you don’t know, alone, etc.).

Thus

- a. If you are a child your reaction may be to cry.
- b. If you are a young man you may feel crying is not socially acceptable, so you may swear loudly instead.

- c. Swearing loudly may be if you are at home by yourself or with someone who accepts the fact that you swear on occasions. Swearing may not be acceptable if for example you are fixing a stranger's fire as part of your job.
- d. If you had been messing around with friends when you burnt your hand, their reaction may be to laugh and make fun of your pain: laughter would not be an acceptable reaction if it was your child that had burnt their hand.

The looking-glass self by Charles Horton Cooley

- Like Mead Cooley believed the individual is a social product, to Cooley the individual and society are one; neither can be understood without the other
- Cooley saw how the centrality of other people's opinions becomes a dominant aspect of our identity; the centrality of the role of others in defining the self. Individual behaviour is thus shaped by what the individual believes is what the larger society expects from them.
- Cooley believed that individuals developed their sense of who they are through social interaction, and he set out to describe the process by which the self emerges.
- According to Cooley, primary groups exert a lasting influence on us and serve as the foundation for the development of our social selves. Individuals tend to reflect the behaviour of others towards them thus the individual is a mirror image of society.
- In contrast to primary groups, with which we interact because it fulfils a basic need, secondary groups are larger, more impersonal groups that fulfil strictly instrumental needs. That is, we join secondary groups to achieve a specific goal or to accomplish a particular task.
- Examples of secondary groups include schools, clubs, governmental organizations, or work.
- As we interact through primary and secondary groups, we notice that the people in these groups react to our behaviours. If these reactions are negative, we will change our behaviours to meet the expectations of the group. If the reactions are positive, those behaviours are reinforced. Thus, we judge our actions and ourselves by how we think we appear to others. Cooley believes through these processes we actually come to be what we believe other people think we are.
- Cooley (1902) termed this the looking-glass self because this process resembles looking in a mirror. **"We see . . . our face, figure, and dress in the glass, and are interested in them because they are ours, and pleased or otherwise with them according as they do or do not answer to what we should like them to be; so in imagination we perceive in another's mind some thought of our appearance, manners, aim . . . and so on, and are variously affected by it."** (Cooley 1902 182).
- The self is continuously constructed through judgments we make about how others see us. Thus, the self is a product of socialization. Cooley saw the process of socialization as lifelong. We are continually attentive of the behaviour cues of others e.g. when dressing we wonder whether they say we look good or whether we are expressing ourselves well. According to Cooley, without socialization a sense of self will not emerge.

- The concept of the looking-glass self implies that the self emerges through the process of interaction.

THEORIES OF SOCIALIZATION

Functionalist Perspectives on Socialization

- The functionalist perspective analyses the social world in terms of the functions that institutions have within the whole social system.

What function does socialization have in society?

- Socialization is the way in which each individual learns about his or her social world.
- Socialization functions as a process by which individuals learn the roles they will play in society, as well as the norms that are appropriate for those roles.
- Socialization functions as a means by which our status in society is constructed and maintained.
- Socialization also functions as a means of cultural transmission. That is, socialization is the process by which we teach others what are appropriate beliefs, values, and behaviours in our society. It is how we pass our culture on to our children.

Socialization through the Conflict Perspective

- The conflict perspective tries to understand the world in terms of competition between groups and individuals for scarce resources.
- The conflict perspective sees socialization as the process by which individuals and groups are taught to compete for resources in society.
- Prejudice and discrimination are taught to individuals as ways for them to justify their position as well as to legitimize differential access to resources.
- In other words, the conflict perspective seeks to understand socialization in terms of how individuals and groups are socialized to compete in society.
- Largely, the conflict perspective sees this competition as socially undesirable and uses this knowledge to develop ways to reduce social conflict and increase social justice.

Socialization and Symbolic Interactionism

- Symbolic interactionism is a perspective that is interested in how social reality is constructed through the use of symbols.
- Since socialization is often transmitted and received through symbols such as language, symbolic interactionism seeks to understand how the process of socialization is transmitted.
- For example, many people see a doctor's white lab coat as a symbol of education, experience, and authority.
- Yet how is this message transmitted?
- Clearly, the white coat is a symbol of a doctor, but how do we learn this?
- Symbolic interactionism seeks to understand how individuals become socialized to understand the workings of our society and how they use this knowledge to be successful in society.

According to Parsons

- Socialisation helps to produce value consensus
- Creation and maintenance of value consensus allows society to meet basic needs; (functional prerequisites)
- Helps individual to internalise society's values i.e. they become part of the individual's personality.
- Socialisation helps in pattern maintenance (common culture)



- Socialisation therefore helps achieve the following
 - o Provides people with common goals
 - o Appropriate behaviour for particular roles e.g. mother, teacher, friend, pastor etc.
 - o Teaches social life norms.

THE NATURE OF PEOPLE WITHOUT SOCIALISATION

The impact of lack of socialisation

Socialization is the process whereby infants and children *develop* into social beings. Among other things;

- Children develop a sense of self, memory, language, and intellect.
- They learn from their elders the attitudes, values, and proper social behaviors of the culture into which they were born.
- Becoming socialized benefits the individual by giving him or her tools needed for success in the native culture. Socialization also benefits the society by providing continuity over time and preserving its essential nature from generation to generation; Socialization connects different generations to each other.

Social Isolation in Monkeys

- Psychologists Harry and Margaret Harlow conducted early studies of social isolation using rhesus monkeys.
- In 1962, the Harlows placed infant monkeys in conditions of varying isolation. What they found was startling.
- The greater the degree of social isolation, the greater was the degree of developmental disturbance.
- Monkeys placed in total isolation for six months showed disturbing and irreversible developmental deficiencies, even when adequate nutrition was provided.
- When these monkeys were brought into a room with other rhesus monkeys, they exhibited extreme passivity in interaction, anxiousness, and fear of other monkeys.
- The Harlows (1964) conducted another experiment in which infant rhesus monkeys were provided with an artificial mother. This artificial mother had a wire body, wooden head, and a feeding tube.
- Monkeys raised by this mother suffered similar developmental deprivations as monkeys raised in isolation.
- Another group of infant monkeys was given an artificial mother made from soft terrycloth. Although these infants did suffer some developmental setbacks, they were able to interact to some degree when placed in a group.
- Furthermore, monkeys raised in social isolation who later become mothers themselves exhibited consistent inability to care for their infants. Most commonly, the new mothers were indifferent to their young, neglecting them to the point of death.
- Based on these experiments, the Harlows concluded that social interaction is a key component to proper development.
- While short-term isolation appears to be reversible to some degree, isolation for longer than about three months appears to lead to permanent developmental damage.

Social Isolation in Children

- The kinds of experiments that the Harlows conducted on monkeys cannot be done on human infants for ethical reasons.
- However, documented cases of children growing up in isolation suggest that the results of the Harlows' experiments would apply to humans as well.



- Despite the tragic nature of these cases, they shed light on the importance of social interaction on the development of the human mind.
- The notion of feral children—that is, children raised in the wild or by animals—is nearly as old as recorded history. For example, Romulus and Remus, legendary founders of the city of Rome, were allegedly raised by wolves.
- However, credible modern cases of feral children do exist, and they shed light on the effects of isolation on the human mind.

1) One such case is the story of Anna.

- Discovered in 1938 by social workers on the second storey of a farmhouse in rural Pennsylvania,
 - Anna lived a life of virtually total isolation from her mentally challenged mother and elderly grandfather.
 - The two fed Anna only milk and kept her locked in a storage room until her discovery at age six.
 - The emaciated Anna could not speak or walk, and she rejected human contact.
 - After extensive socialization over the course of 10 days, Anna was able to interact with others. She began to walk. She found joy in the ability to feed herself and play with toys.
- However, it also became clear that her years of social isolation had caused permanent developmental damage.
- o By age eight, Anna's development was below that of an average two-year old.
 - o By age 10, Anna was using simple words.
 - o Unfortunately, Anna died at age 10 of a blood disease that may have been related to the years of neglect that she had suffered (Davis 1947).

2) In 1970, another feral child was found in California, Genie.

- She was 13 and had spent her life strapped to a potty chair in a dark room.
 - She was rarely spoken to by her blind mother and mentally unstable father.
 - Her only source of stimulation was a raincoat hung on a hook in front of the chair, which Genie could reach out and play with as she sat alone.
 - When Genie was found, she had the mental capacity of an average one-year-old child.
 - Her brain scans revealed no obvious abnormality so the deficiency is assumed to be the result of isolation.
- o Although Genie's physical health improved dramatically, her cognitive improvements were not as spectacular.
 - o After nearly five years of intensive work, her language skills were still equivalent to a small child's. While Genie has learned to do many things for herself, 13 years of social isolation have meant that she must live in a group home for developmentally disabled adults (Rymer 1993).
- **The cases of Anna and Genie illustrate both the power and limitations of socialization.**
 - Individuals who lack appropriate early socialization tend to display developmental delays.
 - Children who are not socialized properly do not develop properly.
 - On the other hand, the failure of attempts at socialization to overcome years of isolation means that there are limits to the plasticity of the human brain.
- 3) One other most commonly cited example of feral children is the *Boy of Aveyron* who emerged little more than a "beast" from a forest in France in 1798.**

"Unsocialized" children such as this boy typically: -

- look more animal than human,
- prefer to remain naked (at least at first upon being discovered),
- lack human speech,
- have no sense of personal hygiene,
- fail to recognize themselves in a mirror,
- show little or no reasoning ability, and

- Respond only partially to attempts to help them change from “animal into human.”

The phenomenon of feral (literally *wild* or untamed) children sparks much discussion regarding the nature versus nurture debate because research shows that the state of these children seems to suggest the important role that learning plays in normal human development.

Social scientists emphasize that socialization is intimately related to *cognitive, personality, and social development*. They argue that socialization primarily occurs during infancy and childhood, although they acknowledge that humans continue to grow and adapt throughout the lifespan.

Note

- The cases of feral children (*who lacked socialisation*) reveal the importance of primary socialization in opening the gates for the subsequent levels of socialization.
- ***Individuals who do not undergo adequate primary socialization within a given period of time will likely not proceed through secondary or adult socialization.***
- ***Instead, as their biological potential is not met, the individuals will remain trapped at the level of a child.***
- Thus, The Critical Period Hypothesis, suggests that there is a window of time for primary socialization to operate. Once this period has passed, primary socialization becomes increasingly difficult and less effective. This suggests that the effects of socialization are strongest and most important at the earlier stages in life.